13. China’s Century of Humiliation and Its Response to the Western Challenge

Having mapped the rise of the Qing empire and its expansion and consolidation under its most powerful ruler, Qianlong (who reigned from 1735 to 1796) in the previous chapter, it is now time to examine its steady decline and fall. While the seeds of its decline were already visible at the turn of the eighteenth century, Chinese historians date the turnaround in its fortunes from its humiliating defeat in the First Opium War of 1839–42 at the hands of the British imperial forces. This was followed by a series of military debacles and the imposition of so-called ‘unequal treaties’ on China by the Western powers, Russia and Japan. This dark phase in China’s history persisted even after the fall of the Qing empire in 1912 and the establishment of a Chinese republic. For the leaders of communist China, it is only with the victory of the communist forces in the civil war against the ruling Guomindang (1945–49) [1] that the ‘Century of Humiliation’ finally came to a close. As Mao Zedong, the leader of victorious forces, declared from the ramparts of Tiananmen Square, ‘China had stood up’. [2]

Significantly, despite claiming to have contributed to the defeat of Japan in the Second World War, the CCP did not identify with China’s status as one of the victorious Allies and a privileged veto-wielding permanent member of the UN Security Council. This is because its expectation that with its victory in the civil war in 1949, the communist regime would replace the KMT government led by Chiang Kai-shek on the UN Security Council was belied. That did not happen as the Korean War broke out and Chinese and US forces clashed on the Korean peninsula; and Taiwan, to which the KMT forces had retreated after their defeat in the civil war, became a military ally of the US, as did a recently defeated Japan. The US would continue to oppose China’s membership of the UN up until 1971. It changed its stance on the eve of US President Nixon’s planned visit to